Tuesday, January 16, 2024
Magh 2, 2080 | Nepal Sambat 1144 | Pohelaathwo Panchami

NATION'S 1ST ENGLISH BROADSHEET

risingnepaldaily.com
Vol. LIX, No. 31 | Pages 8 | Rs. 5 | National Edition

THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

Kathmandu to get safe water in sustainable manner

PM directs to build new distribution network

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 15

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has assured that the government had been making efforts to provide safe and sustainable drinking water to the people of Kathmandu regularly.

Inaugurating the Melamchi drinking water diversion and redistribution ceremony on Monday, PM Prachanda instructed officials to establish a new network for 24/7 water distribution within the Kathmandu Valley, ensuring proportional, safe, and specified quantities of water to the consumers.

The Prime Minister said, "Additional water treatment centre in Sundrijal and new distribution system and wastewater treatment system will also be developed in the Valley."

"In the upcoming years, in the next phase of water distribution within the Kathmandu Valley, I will instruct the relevant agencies to organise a new distribution network ensuring regular distribution of proportional, safe, and specified quantities of water services to consumers."

The Prime Minister further said that the correct decision would be made based on the information provided in the report of the committee, which was formed under the coordination of the former member of the National Planning Commission Dr. Dil Bahadur Gurung for the appropriate compensation when the Italian construction company CMC left the work in in the middle.

He said, "Following the termination of the contract with CMC, which was involved in the construction of the Melamchi water supply project tunnel, various local suppliers associated with the company, as well as the homeowners who rented their properties for warehouse and storage purposes, have not received payments. Dr. Gurung coordinates a committee to investigate this matter and the decision will be made based on the committee's report, PM Prachanda said.

Meanwhile, the inauguration of the Melamchi drinking water marks the fifth occurrence. Former Prime Minister KP Oli inaugurated it for the first time on March 6, 2021, by activating the hydromechanical system in the flushing tunnel of the Sundarijal treatment plant, releasing the water.

A month later, former President Bidya Devi Bhandari initiated water release into the stream constructed in Bhrikutimandap and officially inaugurated it.

However, the water supply was interrupted due to flooding in June 2021. The temporary water supply was reinstated on April 24, 2022, and inaugurated by former Minister for Water Supply Umakant Chaudhary.

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PHOTO: KABITA THAPA/TRN

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' inaugurating the redistribution of water supply from Melamchi to the Kathmandu Valley on Monday.

President urges parties to strengthen federal republic

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan 15

President Ramchandra Paudel has called upon political parties representing the federal parliament to swiftly enact the necessary laws for the complete implementation of the Constitution. He expressed concern that the incomplete enforcement of the Constitution has led to frustration among citizens.

During a reception held at Shital Niwas on the occasion of the Maghi festival on Monday, the Head-of- the-State urged the political parties in the federal parliament to collectively commit to realising the implementation of the federal democratic republic system.

While acknowledging that the Constitution has bestowed empowerment upon marginalised, neglected, excluded and disadvantaged communities, President Paudel highlighted that the international community has praised these provisions. However, he said that these rights are yet to be fully put into practice.

He further said, "Citizens are frustrated not for any other reasons but due to delayed realisation of Constitution's full enforcement. Let's expedite the process of drafting the laws mandated by the Constitution and transform the people's frustrations into hope."



Citing that the citizens of Nepal always lean towards progress rather than regression, he urged everyone to work towards materialising the people's dream of an inclusive federal republic system.

"On this occasion, let's make a resolution to meet the people's aspirations for an inclusive federal republic system," he stated.

Vice President Ram Sahay Prasad Yadav, Speaker Devraj Ghimire, National Assembly Chair Ganesh Timilsina, Vice Chair Urmila Aryal, parliamentary party leaders from various parties in the federal parliament, presidents of parliamentary committees, and independently elected lawmakers were present during the event.

'Let's build quake resistant structures by using local resources and technology'

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Jan. 15

Nepal is observing the 26th Earthquake Safety Day 2080 on Tuesday with various awareness generating and informative programmes across the country.

The main ceremony of the event is being organised in Chandragiri Municipality of Kathmandu district with the slogan 'Let's also use local resources and technology, let's build an earthquake resistant structure!!' according to the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA).

The country observes the Earthquake Safety Day on Magh 2 of Nepali calendar (which falls on January 16 this year) in the memory of the devastating earthquake of 1934 that killed more than 8,500 people and damaged more than 300,000 houses.

Nepal has started observing the Earthquake Safety Day since 1998.

According to Brahma Shumsher Rana, who wrote a book on the 1934 quake a year after the massive earthquake hit central Nepal at 2:24 PM for about 2 minutes. In a week following the quake, there were more than 28 aftershocks.

Nepal is said to be ranked the11th in terms of the potential earthquake risks and has experienced powerful tremors in about every 100 years in the past several centuries. Hence, the Safety Day holds significance here.

» 26TH EARTHQUAKE SAFETY DAY

Historian Mahesh Raj Pant has maintained that the oldest recorded earthquake that hit the nation was happened in 1280 BS (1223 AD).

The earthquake in 2015, which rocked the country about 81 years after the 1934 quake, killed 8,970 people and damaged about 800,000 houses, cultural heritages, education and health facilities as well as several development infrastructures.

An earthquake on November 3 last year killed 154 people in Jajarkot and Rukum West districts and damaged more than 26,000 houses.

Meanwhile, a three-year long risk assessment project undertaken by the government and Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA) that concluded in February 2018, has estimated that if a 7.8 magnitude earthquake hits central Nepal in the south, about 22,000 people would die, and 44.7 per cent of the residential buildings would be damaged in the Kathmandu Valley alone.

This projection was based on the ground shaking behaviour in the Kathmandu Valley during the 2015 earthquake. The estimates are made for the next one and a half decades. It also projected that about 86,860 people would be injured if a 7.8 Richter scale quake hits the nation, and 1,196,080 people would be in the need of evacuation.

Considering these risks, the federal ministries, provincial governments, district administration offices, district coordination committees, local governments and National Society for Earthquake Technology (NSET) are collaborating to mark the day with various events.

It is also decided to provide posters with the slogan of Earthquake Safety Day to schools across the country through the Ministry of Education, Science and Technology, and to conduct awareness programmes related to earthquakes.

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More successful days are ahead: PM

BY RADHA NEPALI
Sandhikharka, Jan. 15

The Prime Minister said that the first year of his third term had succeeded in setting some standards and that he would build on that to achieve greater success in his second year.

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has promised to make his next year in office more successful.

Inaugurating the Arghakhanchi Tourism Promotion Programme at Sandhikharka on Monday, Prime Minister Prachanda said that he was not fully satisfied with the government's works so far and pledged to work more effectively in the coming year.

The programme was organised by the Federation of Nepali Journalists' Arghakhanchi branch with the aim of promoting tourism and boosting the local economy.

Nevertheless, the Prime Minister said that the first year of his third term had succeeded in setting some standards and that he would build on that to achieve greater success in his second year.

Specifically referring to the economy, he said that his government had improved the nation's financial situation. "Our foreign currency reserves are the highest they have ever been. Tourist arrivals have gone up. Banks have reduced their interest rates and issues with cooperatives and micro-finances have been addressed," he counted his achievements.

"Remittance has gone up and the nation's industries have been reinvigorated," he added.

He also informed that acts related to civil service and the adjustment of police personnel would be passed soon.

After the programme, the Prime Minister attended the political and ideological training organised by the CPN (Maoist Centre) in the district. At the training, Prime Minister Prachanda, who is also the Maoist chairman, said that the party was rapidly being reconstructed.

Prime Minister Prachanda further directed his party's leaders and cadres to inform all about the good works carried out by the government and to convey the ideas and principles of the party to the people.

NA election code comes into effect from today

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 15

As the National Assembly election is approaching, the Election Commission Nepal said it would enforce the election code of conduct effective from January 16.

The ECN announced the enforcement of the code of conduct as per the decision of its meeting held on Sunday.

The ECN said that the election code of conduct would be effective from January 16 to 26 according to the Election Commission Act-2073 BS Clause 22 and the Election Code of Conduct -2079 BS Clause (1) Sub-clause (2). The NA election is scheduled for January 25.

ECN Spokesperson Salik Ram Sharma Paudel informed that the code of conduct would be valid during the given timeframe to the government offices as well as all citizens, agencies and officials. According to the code of conduct, the use of public resources and property for or against any election candidate is strictly prohibited. Distortion of election-related contents and information, as well as the use of government schools or publications for electioneering, are also prohibited.

It also restricted the production, sale, distribution, and publicity of materials bearing election symbols or party logos. The use of children, and character assassination in election-related publicity involving women, senior citizens, disabled individuals, and members of sexual and gender minorities are also prohibited.

The ECN restricted various activities such as processions, general assemblies, corner meetings, and election promotional activities.

» SEE PAGE 6

A year on, kin of air tragedy still in trauma

BY RADHAKRISHNA DUMRE
Waling, Jan. 15

It has been a year since the ATR 72-212A aircraft operated by Yeti Airlines crashed in Pokhara, killing all 72 passengers and crew members on board. But to those who lost loved ones, it feels like the accident happened only yesterday.

Saru Dumre, a manager at the Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal (CAAN) who works at the Tribhuvan International Airport (TIA), lost her mother, husband, son and daughter in the crash, with the bodies of her husband, Yuvaraj Sharma, and son, Baby Sharma, never found. This inflicted a trauma that the 34-year-old is still struggling to recover from.

Government bureaucracy caused her more pain. Owing to a lack of bodies, the authorities refused to issue death certificates for Dumre's spouse and son. She spent almost the entire last year fighting and appealing to get their deaths recognised. According to her father Dhakaram Dumre, she finally got the death certificates but only after what felt like a great war. "The insensitivity and irresponsibility of state bodies added to our suffering," he grieved.

"My god, the ordeal we were put through," he recounted. "We were sometimes asked to go to Kathmandu and sometimes to Pokhara. We were tossed around from the District Administration Office of Kaski to the Ministry of Home Affairs, from the Yeti Airlines office to Parbat's Bihadi Rural Municipality.

Saru's little brother Ganesh told The Rising Nepal that the Yeti accident "shattered" her. "She still sometimes goes into a state where she forgets who and where she is. She gets upset but she is not able to cry. Her emotions get stuck at her throat."

"She went through a tragedy that I pray no one ever has to endure." Ganesh also works at CAAN as a senior officer.

Understanding her condition, CAAN has not given Dumre any hard work.

On her husband's side, Dumre only has a brother-in-law now. But since he lives abroad, she is being looked after by her maternal family.

The bodies of only 70 of the 72 people who perished on that flight were recovered and identified, informed Ram Lamichhane, head of Yeti Airlines' Pokhara office. The two bodies never found belonged to Yuvaraj and Baby.

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PHOTO: RADHAKRISHNA DUMRE /TRN

Mayor of Pokhara Metropolitan City Dhana Raj Acharya speaking after inauguration of a memorial at the site of last year's Yeti Air plane crash.

BULLION
(Rs. per tola)

Hallmark Gold	: Rs. 119500
Worked Gold	: Rs. 118950
Silver	: Rs. 1420

STOCK

NEPSE	: 2,120.62
Total Amount	: 5,450,421,806.4
No. of Share	: 16,605,234

FARMERS' PROTEST CONTINUES

AP
Berlin, Jan. 15

Columns of tractors rolled into Berlin on Monday as farmers gathered for the climax of a week of demonstrations against a plan to scrap tax breaks on the diesel they use, a protest that has tapped into wider discontent with Germany's government.

Police said late Sunday evening that the space set aside for vehicles in front of the Brandenburg Gate, where Monday's demonstration was being held, was already full. Over the past week, farmers have blocked highway entrances and slowed down traffic across Germany with their protests, intent on pushing Chancellor Olaf Scholz's government to abandon the planned cuts entirely.

They're not satisfied with concessions the government has already made. On Jan. 4, it watered down its original plan, saying that a car tax exemption for farming vehicles would be retained and the cuts in the diesel tax breaks would be staggered over three years.

Scholz said in a video message on Saturday that "we took the farmers' arguments to heart" and insisted the government came up with "a good compromise." He also said officials will discuss "what else we can do so that agriculture has a good future."

Leaders of the three governing parties' parliamentary groups plan to meet with farmers' representatives, though officials have dampened hopes of scrapping the subsidy cuts.

5,000 households without power in Mugu

RSS
Mugu, Jan. 15

Five thousand households in the district are without access to electricity and the residents are living in darkness. The students have been affected much due to the lack of power supply. The households deprived of power are managing by solar lamps and burning the traditional dry pine splinter (diyalo) for lighting their homes.

People of these households are facing problems charging their mobile phones and operating other electrical appliances, let alone running industries. Similarly, one thousand out of total 2,546 households in the Chhayanath Rara Municipality, the only municipality in the district, do not have electricity.

Likewise, all 3,651 households in Khatyad Rural Municipality are without power and are dependent on the erratic solar lamp and the traditional 'diyalo'. The construction of Birabagar Hydroelectricity Project, initiated to generate power to supply to all houses in the rural municipality, has been in limbo for the last five years.

Likewise, the locals of 55 settlements from ward number 1 to 11 of Soru Rural Municipality do not have power supply to their home. A 60-kilowatt capacity solar power plant has been set up at Sorukot, the rural municipality headquarters, but this is not adequate for the rural municipality to deliver services.

Although the national transmission line has been extended to Gamgadhi, the district headquarters, on September 11, 2023, locals complained that the power supply through this is unreliable.



PHOTO: KABITA THAPA: TRN

An elderly woman weaving Sukul (straw mat) in Sanagaun, Mahalaxmi Municipality-6, Lalitpur.

Rs.20 billion foreign investment mobilised for Langtang-Bhotekoshi

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 15

Foreign investment of approximately Rs 20 billion has been mobilized for the Langtang-Bhotekoshi Hydroelectricity Project based in Rasuwa. The under-construction project has a total capacity of generating 120 megawatts power.

Foreign investment equivalent to Rs 19 billion and 857 million has been brought for the project from the Bank of China of the People's Republic of China, said Nepali Congress leader and lawmaker Deepak Khadka, who is one of the promoters of this project. The total cost of the project is equivalent to Rs 24 billion 954 million and 473 thousand.

The promoters have invested Rs 5 billion 97 million and 473 thousand. This investment has already been brought as self-capital with the approval from the Nepal Rastra Bank, it is said. Rs 19 billion and 857 million has been brought from Bank of China as loan.

Lawmaker Khadka said the entire financing of the project has been managed. The Department of Electricity Development had given until February 14 for managing the investment for the project. Chinese company has 90 percent and the Nepali side 10 percent investment in the project. The Langtang-Bhotekoshi Hydroelectricity Project, the promoter company and the Export Import Bank of China, Sichuan branch had signed an agreement on January 7, 2023 regarding bringing in the investment for the project.

The project forwarded at lawmaker Khadka's initiation is being constructed by the Chinese construction company – Sichuan Huwafei Energy Investment Company Limited. The foundation of the project was aid in January 2020 and construction works are in progress at resent. Projects with the capacity of producing a total 584 megawatts power are at various stages of construction in Rasuwa district.

Country faces fiscal deficit

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 15

The government expenditures in the first half of the current fiscal year 2080-81 BS (2023-24) exceeded the income. Till mid-January, the nation suffered a budget deficit worth Rs. 48.46 billion.

According to the data from the Office of the Auditor General, in the half-yearly review period, the revenue collections met 35.19 per cent of the annual target, while expenditures reached 32.35 per cent.

In the current fiscal year, the government estimated to collect the revenue amounting to Rs. 1472 billion while the collections till mid-January are calculated at Rs. 518 billion and this makes 35.19 per cent of the target.

Towards the tax revenue, the collections amounted to Rs. 443.05 billion, making 33.98 per cent of the target. Similarly, towards the non-taxation collection, the revenue is 45.23 per cent of the target or Rs. 52.094 billion.

A target was set to take foreign grants totalling Rs. 49 billion and 943 million in the current fiscal year and 5 per cent of this amount or Rs. 2 billion and 758 million foreign grant has been received so far.

Out of the total budget of Rs. 1 trillion 751 billion 312 million and 100 thousand annual budget for the current fiscal year, Rs. 566 billion 621 million and 300 thousand has been spent until January 14. This amount of expenditure is equivalent to 32.35 per cent of the annual goal.

Out of the total budget of Rs. 1 trillion 141 billion 784 million and 100 thousand allocated under the current heading, 38.31 per cent or Rs. 437 billion 381 million and 200 thousand has been spent so far.

Tarul Festival organised in Mechinagar



PHOTO: TRN

Cultural performance of the artists at the Tarul Festival.

BY BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL
Damak, Jan. 15

The 2nd Mechinagar Tarul (Yam) Festival has been organised with various cultural and awareness programmes in Bahundangi of Mechinagar Municipality Ward No. 4 for the promotion of indigenous crops. More than 5,000 people from Nepal and India are participating in the festival.

Since last year, Tarul Festival has been organized here on the occasion of Maghe Sankranti to protect the indigenous and local crops. The local crops are on the verge of extinction due to the entry of hybrid and advanced varieties of crops in Nepal.

Tarul festival also displays and sells products including mats from local and hilly areas. Local crops such as Yam, Simal Yam with other verities of local vegetables and crops were exhibited. The festival is being celebrated every year on the occasion of Maghe Sankranti, said Arjun Karki, chairperson of Ward No. 4.

He said that the festival has been organised as it is absolutely necessary to expand such local crops for biodiversity conservation, food supply, obtaining nutritious and medicinal crops and increasing the income level. He said that the yield of indigenous crops found in different places can be secured by less hard work, less care and less damage due to diseases.

Rural tourism expert Raj Vashu, popularly known as The Tourism Gandhi of India, was present at the festival. Participating in the festival, he said that Jhapa and Bahundangi areas have great potential for rural tourism.

He also said that if Nepal and India could collaborate for the development of tourism in rural areas, it would be beneficial for both the countries.

Indigenous crops and food items are also linked to tourism, he said. Stating that the demand for local crops is increasing in the national and international markets, he also urged to promote them.

The indigenous crops, which are rich in nutrients, are disappearing, so he suggested that the festival should be used for the expansion and marketing of such crops.

Oxfam's claim world could get first trillionaire within 10 years

AP
Davos (Switzerland), Jan.15

The world could have its first trillionaire within a decade, anti-poverty organization Oxfam International said Monday in its annual assessment of global inequalities timed to the gathering of political and business elites at the Swiss ski resort of Davos.

Oxfam, which for years has been trying to highlight the growing disparities between the super-rich and the bulk of the global population during the World Economic Forum's annual meeting, reckons the gap has been "supercharged" since the coronavirus pandemic.

The group said the fortunes of the five richest men — Tesla CEO Elon Musk, Bernard Arnault and his family of luxury company LVMH, Amazon founder Jeff Bezos, Oracle founder Larry Ellison and investment guru Warren Buffett — have spiked by 114% in real terms since 2020, when the world was reeling from the pandemic. Oxfam's interim executive director said the report showed that the world is entering a "decade of division."

"We have the top five billionaires, they have doubled their wealth. On the other hand, almost 5 billion people have become poorer," Amitabh Behar said in an interview in Davos, Switzerland, where the forum's annual meeting takes place this week.

"Very soon, Oxfam predicts that we will have a trillionaire within a decade," Behar said, referring to a person who has a thousand billion dollars. "Whereas to fight poverty, we need more than 200 years."

If someone does reach that trillion-dollar milestone — and it could be someone not even on any list of richest people right now — he or she would have the same value as oil-rich Saudi Arabia.

John D. Rockefeller of Standard Oil fame is widely considered to have become the world's first billionaire in 1916. Currently, Musk is the richest man on the planet, with a personal fortune of just under $250 billion, according to Oxfam, which used figures from Forbes.

By contrast, the organization said nearly 5 billion people have been made poorer since the pandemic, with many of the world's developing nations unable to provide the financial support that richer nations could during lockdowns.

In addition, Oxfam said Russia's invasion of Ukraine in February 2022, which sent energy and food costs soaring, disproportionately hit the poorest nations.

With Brazil hosting this year's Group of 20 summit of leading industrial and developing nations, Lawson said it was a "good time for Oxfam to raise awareness" about inequalities. Brazilian President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva has put issues that concern the developing world at the heart of the G20 agenda.

Oxfam said measures that should be considered in an "inequality-busting" agenda include the permanent taxation of the wealthiest in every country, more effective taxation of big corporations and a renewed drive against tax avoidance.

To calculate the top five richest billionaires, Oxfam used figures from Forbes as of November 2023. Their total wealth then was $869 billion, up from $340 billion in March 2020, a nominal increase of 155%. For the bottom 60% of the global population, Oxfam used figures from the UBS Global Wealth Report 2023 and from the Credit Suisse Global Wealth Databook 2019. Both used the same methodology.

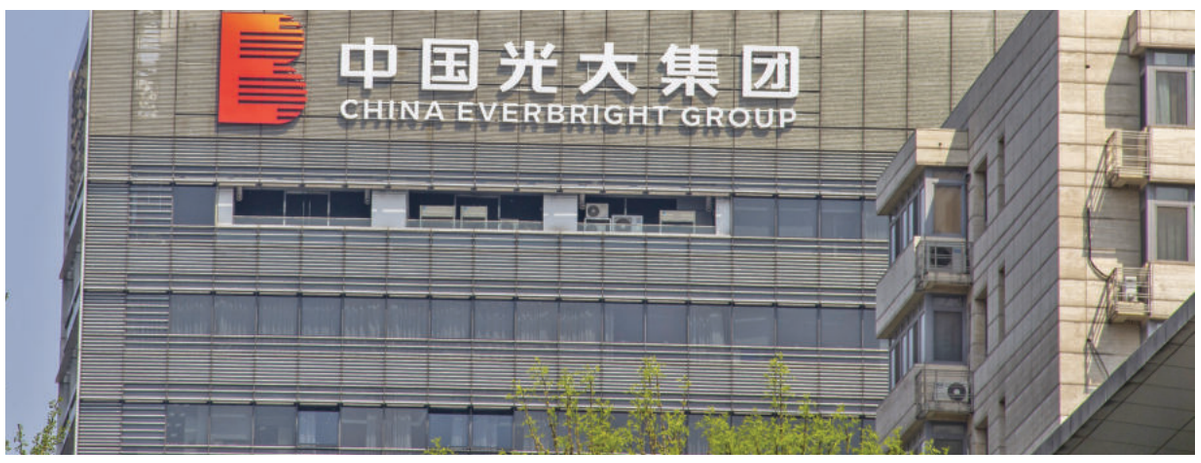
Everbright Group's former chairman arrested for corruption

AP
Hong Kong, Jan.15

The former chairman Tang Shuangning in state-owned Chinese bank China Everbright Group has been arrested on suspicion of embezzlement and bribery, prosecutors said in a statement Monday, amid an intensified campaign against corruption.

The investigation into Tang Shuangning, the former party secretary and chairman of China Everbright Group has ended and the case would be "transferred to the procuratorate for review and prosecution," China's Supreme People's Procuratorate said in a statement. Tang, 69, was expelled from the Chinese Communist Party earlier this month over violations of disciplines and laws, amid a crackdown on corruption in China's financial sector. He retired in 2017.

Other allegations against him include weakening the party's leadership over the bank, failing to prevent and defuse financial risks, "privately reading publications with serious political problems and resisting organizational scrutiny," the party-run



newspaper Global Times cited the Central Commission for Discipline Inspection (CCDI) and the National Supervisory Commission as saying. Another alleged transgression: promoting his calligraphy. Tang has published several volumes of calligraphy and poems.

Chinese president Xi Jinping earlier this month pledged to intensify a crackdown on graft in the finance, energy and infrastructure sectors, part of a longstanding campaign against corruption since he came to power since 2012. As of April 2022, 4.7 million people had been punished for corruption, according to state-owned media reports.

Tang served as vice president of the China Banking Regulatory Commission from 2003 to 2007, before his appointment as chairman of China Everbright Group. He was first investigated in July.

China Everbright is one of about a dozen commercial banks founded in China in the early 1990s. Its shares are listed on the Hong Kong and Shanghai stock exchanges. It is controlled by Central Huijin, a state-owned investment company. Tang's successor Li Xiaopeng was also suspected of graft, expelled from the party and removed from public office.

Others who have been punished for alleged corruption include Sun Guofeng, a former Chinese central bank senior official, who was sentenced to over 16 years in prison for accepting bribes.

Maghe Sankranti marked across country



PHOTO: BASANTA PARAJULI/TRN

Devotees across the country gather at Devghat to take religious bath on the occasion of Maghesankranti festival in Narayani river confluence.

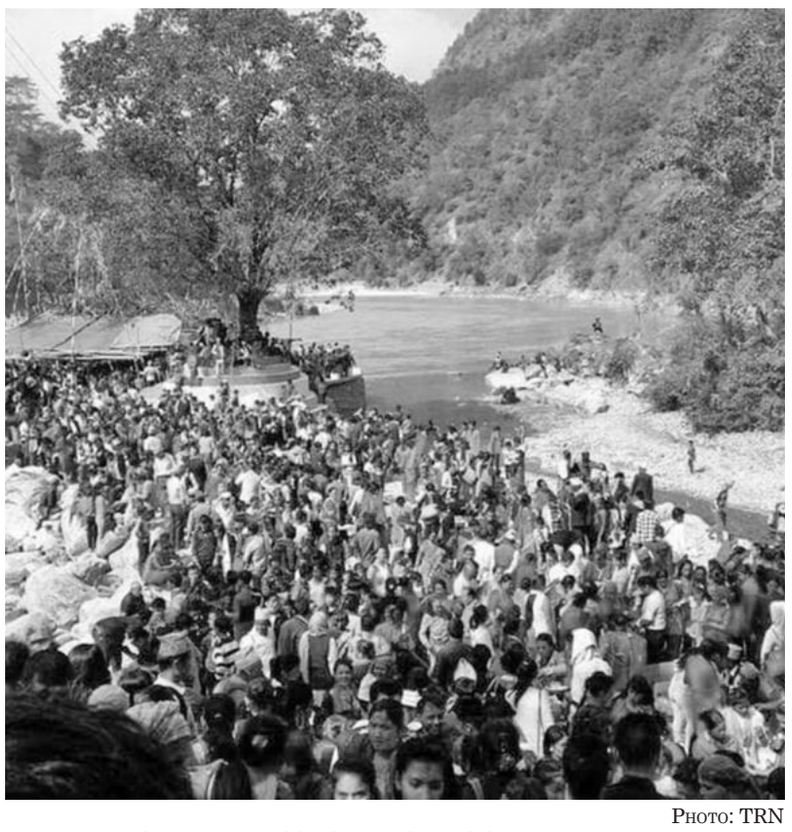


PHOTO: TRN

Devotees performing ritual bath in Kaligandaki river.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Magar women in their traditional attire gathering to celebrate Maghesankranti in Kathmandu.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Tharu women performing their traditional dance at Tundikhel, Kathmandu to mark Maghi.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 15

A big religious fair was held in Devghat of Chitwan and Tanahun district in the confluence of Kaligandaki and Narayani rivers.

Maghe or Makar Sankranti, one of the most popular Nepali festivals, was observed across the country on Monday. The festival marks the sun's transit into Makar (Capricorn) which means the end of winter solstice and the beginning of the longer days. A large number of devotees thronged the confluences of rivers from Maibeni in Ilam in the east to Parshuram in Dadeldhura in the west from the early morning to take a holy dip.

According to our district correspondents, the devotees visited the Maibeni fair organised on the bank of the Jogmai River in Ilam and on the bank of the Kankai River in Jhapa. Likewise, a huge crowd of devotees visited Barahkshetra on the bank of the Koshi River in Sunsari to take a holy bath.

A big religious fair was held in Devghat of Chitwan and Tanahun district in the confluence of Kaligandaki and Narayani rivers. Devotees from across the country as well as India arrived in Devghat to take a bath on the occasion of Maghe Sankranti.

Similar fairs were organised in Panauti of Kavre, Betrawati of Rasuwa, Kaligandaki of Parbat, Gulmi and Syangja districts and the Kali River of Parshuramdham in Dadeldhura district.

The largest crowds of the devotees were seen at Setibeni and Ridi on the banks of the Kaligandaki. After taking a holy bath in the Kaligandaki, the devotees offered worship to the largest Saligram (the stone form of Lord Bishnu) located at Setibeni.

Similarly, the people of Humla marked the day gathering on the bank of the Karnali River in Kharpunath. The devotees stayed awake the whole night by singing and dancing in groups on the river bank.

In Kathmandu, both the Tharu and Magar communities organised separate fairs in Tundikhel.

Although people of all castes and ethnic groups observed Maghe Sankranti by taking baths in the holy rivers across the country, worshipping at the shrines of lord Shiva, and enjoying sweet potato, yam, khichadi, molasses and other delicacies. The Magar and Tharu communities mark it with much fanfare gathering at a single place. For Tharus, the festival is also a New Year's Day.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Magar people in their traditional attire gathering to celebrate Maghesankranti in Kathmandu.

KTWR distributes Rs.2 million as relief

BY JAYAKRISHNA YADAV
Inaruwa, Jan. 15

The allocation of relief amount is based on the damages incurred to the houses and crops in the central area of the reserve caused by wild animals that frequently venture out of Koshi Tappu Wildlife Reserve (KTWR) and cause havoc in the fields and settlements nearby.

Koshi Tappu Wildlife Reserve located in Sunsari district, has disbursed nearly Rs. 2 million in relief and compensation within the first six months of the current fiscal year.

The allocation of relief amount is based on the damages incurred to the houses and crops in the central area of the reserve caused by wild animals that frequently venture out of Koshi Tappu Wildlife Reserve (KTWR) and cause havoc in the fields and settlements nearby.

A total of Rs. 1.98 million in relief and compensation has been recommended for the period spanning mid-July to mid-January of the current fiscal year for 245 victims.

Ramesh Kumar Yadav, Chief Conservation Officer of the reserve said, "The reserve provided relief fund amounting to Rs. 1.72 million for crop damages and Rs. 118,500 for damage incurred to the houses.

In the last fiscal year, the reserve distributed relief and compensation totalling Rs. 3.69 million to 434 affected individuals.

Similarly, in the fiscal year 2021/2022, the reserve provided relief and compensation amounting to Rs. 8.82 million to 451 affected individuals, said Yadav.

Over the last three years, wild animals from the KTWR have been causing damage to the homes, stores, and crops of around 1,130 farmers and residents.

Relief distribution was carried out following an assessment of the incurred damages. Relief amounts vary, starting from a minimum of Rs. 2,000 and reaching up to a maximum of Rs. 1 million for the casualties.

RS.3 MILLION OFFERINGS COLLECTED IN A MONTH IN PATHIVARA TEMPLE

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Taplejung, Jan. 15

In the past month alone, more than Rs. 3 million has been received as offerings at the famous pilgrimage site Pathibhara in Taplejung.

According to a press statement issued by Prajin Hangbang, the Executive Director of the Pathibhara Area Development Committee, a total of Rs. 3,529,000 was collected in the month of Poush, the ninth month of the Nepali year. It read that the collected amount has been deposited in the committee's account held at various banks, including Nepal Bank Limited, Sanima Bank, and NMB Bank. The committee has a total of Rs. 87,052,548 in its accounts. Earlier, till Mangsir, the eighth month of the Nepali year, it had Rs. 83,523,548.

18th liver transplant performed

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Bhaktapur, Jan. 16

In a groundbreaking achievement, the Martyr Dharmabhakta Human Organ Transplant Centre has completed its 18th liver transplant, marking a significant milestone in the field of organ transplantation.

Two consecutive liver transplants were performed in January, bringing the total number of liver transplants to 18.

Additionally, the centre has performed kidney transplants on 1181 individuals, showcasing its commitment to saving lives through organ transplantation.

Under the leadership of senior kidney and liver transplant surgeon Dr. Pukar Chandra Shrestha, the centre has become a hub for organ transplantation, with 10 liver transplants and 138 kidney transplants conducted in the fiscal year 2023/24 alone. Dr Shrestha, who also serves as the executive director of the centre, emphasised the centre's dedication to providing high-quality services at the most affordable prices globally.

Liver transplantation, considered one of the most complex surgeries, has become a routine practice at the Martyr Dharmabhakt Human Organ Transplant Centre, demonstrating the medical team's expertise and proficiency in handling intricate procedures.

The centre's success not only reflects advancements in medical science but also highlights its commitment to making life-saving treatments accessible to a wider population.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

For success, attitude is equally as important as ability.

-- Walter Scott

EDITORIAL

Revive Construction Sector

Across much of the world, including Nepal, construction industry is seen as a bellwether of a country's economy. One of the major drivers of economic growth, it signals where the economy is heading. Because the industry's ability to generate mass employment is almost unmatched, it's imperative that it be kept in good health. Yet ever since the COVID-19 hit, the industry has been in the doldrums, though many other industries, including tourism, have shown signs of recovery. These are a litany of factors ailing this sector.

First, the quality of works. It's so common for a newly constructed road, supposedly built to last for years, to get peeled off in a few weeks or months after its construction is completed and handed over. Similarly, it no longer raises our eyebrows when we see freshly constructed building wearing cracks. In fact, the problem is so dire that there are glaring instances of billions of rupees worth of projects featuring the construction of bridge, irrigation canal, water supply project and many others that came crashing down only a few months into their inauguration. And most of the time faulty design that failed to take into account probable catastrophic events, use of substandard materials, and cutting corners to evade the mandated guidelines are blamed.

Second, delay in disbursement of government fund. Many 'cash-starved' contractors have long complained that they had yet to receive the payment of the completed works because the government failed to release the fund in time. The government, for its part, cite many reasons for its reluctance to release the money, like substandard work, cost overrun, or non-compliance with the stated standards. Third, a contractor company running away, leaving the project in limbo. There are numerous still-incomplete bridges or buildings across the country even years after the contracted company fled, abandoning the project midway through.

The tendency to bid a project at a rate lower than it would cost at the end of its course just to outbid the competitors is mainly responsible for this. That said, there are also a good number of well-reputed contractors with unblemished track record. The government mustn't let them down. The good news is that with enough political will these plaguing issues can be sorted out. What the government's unwavering focus should be on is achieving the development target. And without spending the earmarked budget, this goal will remain elusive. That the government only spent a tiny fraction of such budget is a serious problem repeating year after year. It could, for example, spend only 15.52 per cent of the total capital allocation for the current fiscal year so far.

But in a positive move, it has decided to clear its dues with the payment of Rs. 8.1 billion to contractors, who are demanding that it also clear the remaining pending dues of Rs. 40 billion. Not only to reinvigorate the economy but also to help businesses stay afloat, it's crucial that the budgeted money floods the market. And construction sector can easily absorb that money. Many crumbling public infrastructures like bridges, roads, hospitals, etc. are in dire need of facelift, and the release of the money will work wonders to give them a new lease of life.

Docs Dispel Myth About Benefits Of Lemon Water

IRINA GUSAKOVA

It is believed that lemon water helps you quickly lose weight, improves digestion and strengthens the immune system. Gastroenterologist, doctor, expert of the Hemotest laboratory Ekaterina Kashukh told Pravda.Ru readers whether this is really so.

Lemon water - should everyone start their day with it? Starting your morning with a glass of water with a slice of lemon on an empty stomach is a fashionable trend. But there are no reliable scientific studies that would confirm the exceptional benefits of this habit.

"The advice to drink water with lemon is often argued that this will help start digestion and speed up metabolism, that is, metabolism.

Allegedly, thanks to lemon, the body will absorb nutrients and vitamins faster and better. This is not entirely true.

Water itself is important for normal digestion. It softens the bolus of food and facilitates its smooth passage through the intestines during digestion. And lemon does not play any role here," explains the doctor.

Lemon water can be a source of vitamin C, which is actually abundant in citrus.

Ascorbic acid is an important nutrient for health. It is involved in iron metabolism and collagen production, thanks to which folic acid and vitamin E are better absorbed. In addition, vitamin C is a powerful antioxidant that protects cells from premature aging. But water to which a few slices of lemon has been added has little vitamin C.

It seems much easier to eat a few tangerines. And many berries, fruits and vegetables are rich in antioxidants, comments Ekaterina Kashukh.

Another popular argument for lemon water concerns blood pressure. "There are several studies that have shown that lemon helps lower systolic blood pressure (indicated by the first or top number on the tonometer). But treating this as a therapeutic recommendation is dangerous. High blood pressure is a symptom that indicates some kind of disorder in functioning of the body.

Therefore, it is important to discuss high blood pressure with a doctor - he will help you find the cause of this condition and select effective treatment," the specialist advises.

Finally, lemon water is often credited with its ability to balance the acid-base balance. The functioning of internal organs and systems and the work of digestive enzymes depend on the PH level. But a healthy body itself is able to regulate the acid-base balance. But if for some reason it is broken, it needs to be corrected with the help of a doctor.

So, according to the doctor, whether or not to add lemon to water is a matter of taste.

"To maintain health, a person needs to drink enough water every day. And if you don't like drinking plain water, you can add a couple of slices of lemon, fresh cucumber or a few mint leaves to it.

It is important to remember that lemon may be contraindicated for people with gastrointestinal diseases -intestinal tract. And excess vitamin C can lead to stomach upset," the doctor sums up.

-- Pravda.ru

An Ascetic's Fall From Grace

Narayan Upadhyay



After being on the run for several years, a self-proclaimed ascetic was apprehended at his home. Ram Bahadur Bamjan, popularly known as a Buddha boy because of his years of meditation in solitude under a tree in a dense forest in Bara district, has been accused of rape and the forced disappearance of multiple people from his ashrams or hermitages. After a few nuns from his ashrams, one of whom was a minor, accused him of raping them, authorities launched an investigation but failed to arrest him since Bamjan remained in hiding for nearly five years following the accusations.

After a popular online news site carried feature stories on Bamjan's "victims," police increased their search for the fugitive "ascetic." It has also been reported that, due to political interference, the police had to halt their search until last week, when a team from the Central Investigation Bureau stormed his house in the capital and arrested him, following which he was produced to the district court, which later sent him to custody for allowing the police to complete an investigation into the charges the "ascetic" has been facing.

Unethical acts

The Bamjan case has brought to light a number of other cases in which religious leaders, scholars, and priests in Nepal have been accused of rape, murder, deception, and other unethical behaviour. Along with Bamjan, Baba Krishna Giri of Sunsari, Sri Niwas Acharya of Morang, pastor Dhruba Baba Joshi of Lalitpur, Govinda Rimpochhe, Priest Maulavi, and religious leader Chhatra Bahadur Gurung of Ilam were arrested for raping their followers in the past few years. Similarly, a few other religious leaders were involved in defrauding people out of millions of rupees. Swami Shivananda, Bijay Bhandari, and Purushottam Kafle of Dolakha were arrested for cheating people of tens of thousands of rupees under various pretexts during different periods.

Lhyarkal Lama, a former National Assembly member, a Buddhist scholar, and currently chairperson of the Lumbini Development Trust, was allegedly suspected of having dual citizenship in Nepal and India, storing firearms in his bank locker, and unlawfully dealing with foreign currency. Religious leaders, scholars, and priests of many kinds, not only from Nepal but also from India and abroad, have gained notoriety for their alleged involvement in immoral behaviours such as sexual assaults, cheating, and lying. A few years ago, Asha Ram Babu, Ram Rahim, and some others in India were sentenced to prison for raping women in their own ashrams. Many of them, including Asha Ram and Ram Rahim, are still imprisoned.

The accusations levelled against our religious leaders and high-ranking priests have claimed that these priests are no different from others who seek all the trappings of an opulent life. Though priests and religious leaders are admired for living simple lives and having strong moral character, some of them frequently show the flaws of ordinary mortals. The demand for priesthood can be too much for them at times, and they simply melt under its weight, forcing them to commit crimes that lead them to fall from grace and land them in jail.

> If the spiritual leaders indulge in immoral and criminal behaviour, no one can save them from the prying eyes of the law.

Bamjan began his widely popular monastic lifestyle at the age of 15, but is now accused of molesting multiple girls and women who joined his ashram as nuns or maids. The victims portray him as a sexual predator. In the meantime, police accused him of living a lavish lifestyle in a fancy capital mansion, where he kept millions of rupees in cash. He also had expensive vehicles and automobiles.

Meanwhile, some of Bamjan's ardent Buddhist supporters have claimed that some forces were behind his arrest, and defended him stating that he was crucial in halting the spread of Christianity in Nepal by attracting people to his sect. His followers stated that his reputation as a Bodhisattva has made many of his adherents, thereby opposing the mounting challenges of Christian missionaries in the country who have been converting innocent, underprivileged Nepalis by offering cash and love to them. These forces, according to his supporters, have hatched a plot against him after his popularity soared.

Despite claims from his disciples and supporters, some people think Bamajan may have committed acts that may be considered illegal in court. If we trust the news reports and police accusations, the young ascetic may face the penalty under the country's laws. However, in his responses to the police interrogation, Bamjan denied all charges against him, claiming that because he was a godman completely engrossed in meditation, he was unaware of mundane happenings and thus was completely uninformed of the charges levelled against him. Now a simple question arises: if he is not guilty of any wrongdoing, why did he go into hiding for so long?

Common sense

Priests, religious leaders, and scholars frequently draw the attention of society and the nation, often for the wrong reasons. They frequently cause uproar by acting in ways that defy their stature in society. As a result, they become an eyesore to the many social leaders and individuals who respect the law and urge others, regardless of their social standing, to do the same. Common sense tells us that people who have high regard in society must remain at the forefront to set an example for the rest of us to follow. If the spiritual leaders indulge in immoral and criminal behaviour, no one can save them from the prying eyes of the law. In recent years, the authorities and lawmakers have made anti-rape and molestation laws stricter.

Finally, we should not forget one thing: with so many followers, resources at their disposal, and a kind of nexus with those associated with politics and politicians, some religious leaders, priests, and ascetics can avoid punishment. We should not be astonished or stunned if Bamjan avoids any punishment by proving his accusers wrong. We cannot say anything for sure. To become certain about the fate of popular ascetics, we must wait for the court ruling.

(Upadhyay is former managing editor of this daily.)

End Overdependence On Remittance

Uttam Maharjan



Nepal is a country which is preponderantly dependent on remittances, taxes and imports to get its economy rolling. Remittances contributes greatly to the gross domestic product (GDP). In 2022/23, the contribution of remittances to the GDP stood at 22 per cent. Remittances have transformed the country, especially rural areas. Increasing inflows of remittance money from abroad through the labour of the country's migrant workers have increased savings for poor rural households. As a matter of fact, remittances have the lion's share in reducing poverty, thus creating economic security for the households receiving remittances on a regular basis.

The poverty rate of the country was 25.2 per cent in 2010, which came down to 16.6 per cent in 2019. As per the Economic Survey of 2022/23, the poverty rate stands at 15.1 per cent. According to the survey by the Nepal Rastra Bank (NRB) in 2014/15, 23.9 per cent of the remittance money is spent on essentials such as food, clothing and health. Besides, remittances have helped increase foreign currency reserves, investments and consumption. Remittances also play a pivotal role in stabilising currency, managing the balance of payments (BOP), bringing about stability in imports and maintaining economic resilience. All this has bolstered the economy of the country. It is said that but for remittances the economy of the country would have collapsed.

Improved living standards

On the one hand, remittances have greatly contributed to improving the standard of living of the poor households, while on the other the country is facing a shortage of manpower for agricultural, construction and other development activities. The rural areas are mostly devoid of youths with the elderly, women and children left behind. Although young women are also working abroad as migrant workers, their number is limited vis-à-vis that of male youths. It is estimated that out of those going abroad for employment, men constitute 81 per cent, and women 19 per cent.

Nepal has over two hundred years of history of migration to foreign countries to work and to take part in wars. Many Nepali youths went to India for jobs and to serve as soldiers during World Wars I and II. As per the Department of Foreign Employment, 3,605 Nepalis left the country for foreign employment in 1993/94. The situation changed drastically in 2000, when the Maoist insurgency was at its peak. In 2000/01, upwards of 55,000 Nepalis left the country for foreign employment.

In recent years, Nepalis are leaving the country for foreign employment in hordes. In 2022/23, over 750,000 people left the country. Since the outbreak of the COVID-19 pandemic, economic activities have got roiled in the country. There has been a slump in business and commercial activities. The people have grown frustrated. This may have added to the number of Nepalis going abroad for job opportunities. Needless to say, the country is unable to create adequate job opportunities.

Although remittances are lucrative, some negative social impacts have also debouched. Social consequences regarding family and gender relations are profound owing to the remittance factor. Men being away from home, some women may indulge in immoral activities with other men, or they may elope with other men. Or, they may make off with the money received from their husbands. All this may lead to family breakdown. Divorces are also on the rise among the migrant families. Health issues such as the incidence of HIV-AIDs may also arise owing to promiscuous behaviour of both men and women. It is reported that the incidence of HIV-AIDA among the migrant workers is higher than the national average.

> If the trend of the exodus of Nepalis continues, a time may come when the country will have to hire workers from foreign countries. So the government should adopt a policy of retaining youths in the country.

Another negative aspect – and which is worrying- is declining agricultural yield. Foreign employment has affected the agriculture sector to a great extent. Agricultural land in the rural areas is lying barren for lack of manpower, affecting agricultural production and productivity. Despite having remittance money, the remittance-receiving households do not show interest in engaging in agriculture. Such households should invest in agricultural machinery and technology to give a boost to agriculture and allied activities.

However, migration of men abroad has played a crucial role in empowering women in some parts of the country. The women are forced to look after household affairs and engage in community activities. They are taking both household and community decisions on their own. The women's participation in community activities has improved maternal health. The maternal mortality is declining.

Gaping trade deficit

In this age of globalisation, migration for foreign employment should be taken as a normal activity. However, overdependence on remittances is not desirable. The migrant workers are sending money back home. But it has also hampered economic activities in the country. Now, a shortage of manpower has been felt. The country has turned from an exporter of agricultural products to an importer. The imports preponderate over the exports, resulting in a gaping trade deficit. Prioritising imports by neglecting agricultural, industrial and other activities does not bode well for the economy of the country in the long run. Further, paradigm shifts in global economic activities and migration may affect the remittance sector on an unprecedented scale.

If the trend of the exodus of Nepalis continues, a time may come when the country will have to hire workers from foreign countries. So the government should adopt a policy of retaining youths in the country. For this, job opportunities should be created in the country itself. The government should pay attention to agricultural and industrial sectors. These are the sectors that can create job opportunities. Further, the government should also prioritise the service sector.

(Maharjan has been regularly writing on contemporary issues for this daily since 2000.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 16, 1974

Mad Dogs Create Nuisance In Banepa

Banepa, Jan 15: Mad dogs are creating a nuisance in Banepa, reports RSS.

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READER'S MAIL

Cutting-edge Technology Aids Business

Over the last two decades, there have been technological breakthroughs in numerous sectors worldwide, ushering in a new era for all types of businesses. Thanks to technological leaps, much of the information can be shared through text, video, sound and images, all on the instant. Such technological advantages have changed the way people live. Furthermore, business intelligence has got a new fillip through sharing as much crucial data as possible. Among numerous technological developments in information technology, the domain of AI (Artificial Intelligence) takes precedence over all else.

In the simplest terms, AI is a science of making intelligent machines or computer programmes. Thanks to the robust datasets stored into the artificial intelligence system, AI can think and act like mankind by demonstrating problem-solving and decision-making capabilities. Basically, algorithms tell or dictate computers to do tasks. With the so-called self-correction algorithms, AI programming can produce the most precise results. The application of

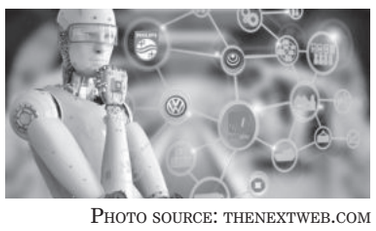


PHOTO SOURCE: THENEXTWEB.COM

the internet has just turned the world upside down literally. With its far-reaching advantages and widest coverage, the world has shrunk into a global village.

With an increased emphasis on innovation and technology, modern businesses including factories can make a significant difference in their operations versus the environmental impacts. Additionally, the concept of a circular economy will play its big part in ensuring a green economy by significantly reducing the environmental threats from the production and consumption of products.

P. Senthil Durai
Mumbai, India.

TAILPIECE

A dentist ran out of anaesthetic just before the last extraction for the day was scheduled.

He gave the nurse a very large needle, instructing her to jab it hard into the patient's butt when the signal was given, so it would take his attention away from the tooth extraction.

It all happened in an instant.

The nurse, patient, and pliers were in place. The signal was given, and the nurse bayoneted the patient with the needle just as the dentist yanked the tooth.

Afterwards, the dentist asked, "Hurt much?"

The patient hesitated, "Didn't hardly feel it come out. And, man, those roots were really deep!"

'Palestinian authority not in position to govern in Gaza'

AFP
Rafah, Jan. 15



PHOTO: AFP

A picture taken from Rafah shows a rainbow over the southern Gaza Strip on January 11, 2024, amid ongoing battles between Israel and Palestinian Hamas militants in the Gaza Strip.

The Israeli government recently laid out its plans for the future governance of Gaza once its war with Hamas is over. The proposal released on January 4 made clear that the Islamist movement would no longer control the besieged Palestinian enclave. However, there was also little provision for the return of the Palestinian Authority.

After three months of war between Israel and Hamas, Israel laid out a plan on January 4 for the "day after" in Gaza for the first time since the conflict began.

The proposal, although lacking in details, outlined a sort of roadmap for Gaza's future governance – a key concern of Israel's ally, the United States.

It has already met with sharp criticism. For some, it was too superficial. For others, like army spokesperson Daniel Hagari, the proposal revealed the state's secret plans to its "enemies".

Presented by Israeli Defence Minister Yoav Gallant on the eve of a visit by US Secretary of State Antony Blinken, the proposal hinges on Israel achieving its main military objective – destroying Hamas in the Gaza Strip.

"Hamas will not govern Gaza and Israel will not govern Gaza's civilians. Gaza residents are Palestinian, therefore Palestinian bodies will be in charge, with the condition that there will be no hostile actions or threats against the State of Israel," said Gallant in a statement. "The entity controlling the territory will build on the capabilities of the existing administrative mechanism (civil committees) in Gaza – local non-hostile actors," the Israeli defence minister added.

"It is very important that at long last a very senior political figure in Israel is outlining a political plan for the future. I know he was criticised by the army spokesperson, who said that it is too early to reveal our secret plans. I don't agree with [Daniel Hagari]," explained David Shimoni, a former member of Israel's intelligence services and a member of Commanders for Israel's Security (CIS), a thinktank bringing together 400 former members of the security forces, the army and Israeli intelligence.

"It sounds very good to me that first of all, Israel will not be governing Gaza. Second, that Hamas will not be governing Gaza. That is, of course, the main goal of this war."

The Israeli government's plan is simple on paper, but difficult to implement, as many Palestinians support Hamas. According to a poll carried out between November 22 and December 2 by the Palestinian Centre for Policy and Survey Research (PSR), 42% of the population of Gaza support Hamas, compared with 38% at the start of the war.

The Islamist movement is especially gaining traction in the occupied West Bank: 44% of residents today say they support the party, compared to 12% in September. The rise in support for Hamas may also be explained by the growing unpopularity of Palestinian Authority President Mahmoud Abbas.

Yemen Houthi rebels fire missile at US warship

AP
Jerusalem, Jan. 15

Yemen's Houthi rebels fired an anti-ship cruise missile toward an American destroyer in the Red Sea but a U.S. fighter jet shot it down in the latest attack roiling global shipping amid Israel's war with Hamas in the Gaza Strip, officials said.

The attack on Sunday marks the first U.S.-acknowledged fire by the Houthis since America and allied nations began strikes Friday on the rebels following weeks of assaults on shipping in the Red Sea.

The Houthis have targeted that crucial corridor linking Asian and Mideast energy and cargo shipments to the Suez Canal onward to Europe over the Israel-Hamas war, attacks that threaten to widen that conflict into a regional conflagration.

The Houthis, a Shiite rebel group allied with Iran that seized Yemen's capital in 2014, did not immediately acknowledge the attack.

It wasn't immediately clear whether the U.S. would retaliate for the latest attack, though President Joe Biden has said he "will not hesitate to direct further measures to protect our people and the free flow of international commerce as necessary."

The Houthi fire on Sunday went in the direction of the USS Laboon, an Arleigh Burke-class destroyer operating in the southern reaches of the Red Sea, the U.S. military's Central Command said in a statement.

The missile came from near Hodeida, a Red Sea port city long held by the Houthis, the U.S. said.

"An anti-ship cruise missile was fired from Iranian-backed Houthi militant areas of Yemen toward USS Laboon," Central Command said. "There were no injuries or damage reported."

The first day of U.S.-led strikes Friday hit 28 locations and struck more than 60 targets with cruise missiles and bombs launched by fighter jets, warships and a submarine. Sites hit included weapon depots, radars and command centers, including in remote mountain areas, the U.S. has said.

The Houthis have yet to acknowledge how severe the damage was from the strikes, which they said killed five of their troops and wounded six others.

U.S. forces followed up with a strike Saturday on a Houthi radar site.

Shipping through the Red Sea has slowed over the attacks. The U.S. Navy on Friday warned American-flagged vessels to steer clear of areas around Yemen in the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden for 72 hours after the initial airstrikes.

For their part, the Houthis alleged without providing evidence that the U.S. struck a site near Hodeida on Sunday around the same time of the cruise missile fire. The Americans and the United Kingdom did not acknowledge conducting any strike — suggesting the blast may have been from a misfiring Houthi missile.

Since November, the rebels have repeatedly targeted ships in the Red Sea, saying they were avenging Israel's offensive in Gaza against Hamas.

Ukraine claims it shot down 2 Russian command aircrafts

AP
Kyiv, Ukraine, Jan. 15



PHOTO: AP

A Russian Beriev A-50 airborne early warning and control plain flies over Red Square during a rehearsal for the Victory Day military parade in Moscow, Russia, on May 7, 2019.

The Ukrainian air force shot down a Russian Beriev A-50 early warning and control plane and an IL-22 command centre aircraft in a significant blow for the Kremlin's forces, Ukraine's military chief Valeriy Zaluzhnyi claimed Monday.

The planes are key tools in helping orchestrate Russian battlefield movements.

Shooting them down is a landmark feat for Ukraine in the almost two-year war, as fighting along the front line is largely bogged down in trench and artillery warfare.

Zaluzhnyi did not say how the aircraft were brought down, but Ukraine has received sophisticated modern air defense systems from its Western allies.

He also did not say where the interception occurred, though he attached a video to his social media post with an airplane tracker showing two targets disappearing above the Azov Sea, which lies between Ukraine and Russia, north of the Crimea Pensinsula and the Black Sea.

There was no immediate official comment from Moscow.

Russian war bloggers said both planes had come under friendly fire, though they presented no evidence of that.

They claimed the Il-22 was damaged but made a successful landing.

The A-50 is an early warning and control aircraft with a large radar capable of spotting air targets at distances of up to 650 kilometres (400 miles). It has a crew of 15. The Russian air force reportedly has been operating a fleet of nine such aircraft.

An A-50 was damaged by a February 2023 drone attack at an airfield in Belarus where it was parked, but Russian and Belarusian officials said it sustained only minor damage.

The Il-22 is an airborne command post, intended to oversee military operations and relay radio signal to troops on the front line.

The Russian air force reportedly has a dozen such planes.

Arévalo sworn in as Guatemala's president

AP
Guatemala City, Jan. 15



PHOTO: AP

Incoming Guatemalan President Bernardo Arévalo receives the presidential sash during his swearing-in ceremony in Guatemala City, early Monday, Jan. 15, 2024.

Bernardo Arévalo was sworn in as Guatemala's president on Monday minutes after midnight despite months of efforts to derail his inauguration, including foot-dragging and rising tensions right up until the transfer of power.

Arévalo arrives in the presidency after winning August's elections by a comfortable margin. But nothing has been straightforward since, with Attorney General Consuelo Porras and the establishment forces observers say she represents throwing one legal challenge after another at Arévalo and his party.

"It fills me with deep honour to assume this lofty responsibility, showing that our democracy has the necessary strength to resist and that through unity and trust we can change the political panorama in Guatemala," Arévalo said in his first address as president.

Arévalo thanked Guatemala's youth for not losing hope and the country's Indigenous peoples for their support, acknowledging "historic debts that we must resolve." He summarized his administration's guiding principle as: "There cannot be democracy without social justice and social justice cannot prevail without democracy."

Despite hundreds of Arévalo's supporters pressuring lawmakers to follow the constitution, even clashing with riot police outside the congress building Sunday, the inauguration process dragged for hours before he took the oath of office just past midnight.

A progressive academic-turned-politician and son of a Guatemalan president credited with implementing key social reforms in the mid-20th century, Arévalo takes office with expectations of confronting Guatemala's entrenched corruption. But it will not be easy.

PRISM

Rats accounting for most of the mischief

Southwest England: Breakdowns caused by animals somehow making their way inside vehicles have reached record levels - with rats accounting for most of the mischief.

According to the RAC, the firm was called out to 303 incidents of animal damage in the first 11 months of 2023, which is more than the same period during any other year on record. It's also a massive 55% increase from the 196 incidents reported between January and November in 2018.

The figures do not include incidents when a vehicle has struck an animal.

More than half of the animal damage this year was caused by rats, which are often found gnawing away at fuel hoses, infesting engine bays and breaking headlights.

Hundreds of manatees gather to keep warm

Florida: The Southwest Florida Water Management District shared video from a gathering of hundreds of manatees at Three Sister Springs in Crystal River.

The SFWMD posted a drone video to Facebook showing the manatees that gathered in the springs while "seeking refuge from the chilly temperatures" in waters elsewhere.

"This is a great demonstration of why the district recently restored the shoreline around Three Sisters Springs," the post said. "The project repaired the eroded shoreline and will help prevent future erosion caused by manatee and human activity."

(AP)

TODAY IN HISTORY

1458 BC – Hatshepsut dies at the age of 50 and was buried in the Valley of the Kings.
1537 – Bigod's Rebellion, an armed insurrection attempting to resist the English Reformation, begins.
1547 – Grand Duke Ivan IV of Muscovy becomes the first Tsar of Russia, replacing the 264-year-old Grand Duchy of Moscow with the Tsardom of Russia.
1605 – The first edition of El ingenioso hidalgo Don Quijote de la Mancha (Book One of Don Quixote) by Miguel de Cervantes is published in Madrid, Spain.
1707 – The Scottish Parliament ratifies the Act of Union, paving the way for the creation of Great Britain.
1780 – American Revolutionary War: Battle of Cape St. Vincent.
1786 – Virginia enacts the Statute for Religious Freedom authored by Thomas Jefferson.
1900 – The United States Senate accepts the Anglo-German treaty of 1899 in which the United Kingdom renounces its claims to the Samoan islands.

Arctic freeze continues to blast across US

AP
Portland, Ore., Jan. 15

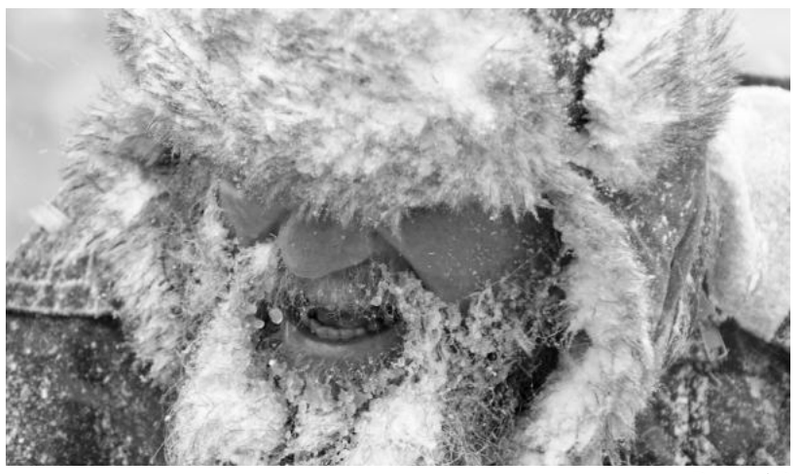


PHOTO: AP

A worker helps remove snow from Highmark Stadium in Orchard Park, N.Y., Sunday Jan. 14, 2024. A potentially dangerous snowstorm that hit the Buffalo region on Saturday led the NFL to push back the Bills wild-card playoff game against the Pittsburgh Steelers from Sunday to Monday

A dangerous Arctic blast will continue sweeping across the U.S. on Monday and linger through at least midweek, prolonging a bitter cold that set record-low temperatures in parts of the country and threatens to further disrupt daily life, including an NFL playoff game and the first-in-the-nation presidential nominating contest in Iowa.

The National Weather Service said wind chills are expected to push temperatures 30 degrees below zero from the Northern Rockies to northern Kansas and into Iowa, testing the hardiness of caucusgoers willing to brave the deep chill on Monday.

"You can't sit home," former President Donald Trump told supporters Sunday. "If you're sick as a dog, you say, 'Darling, I gotta make it.' Even if you vote and then pass away, it's worth it."

Arctic storms left at least four dead and knocked out electricity to tens of thousands in the Northwest, brought snow to the South and walloped the Northeast with blizzard conditions forcing the postponement of the Pittsburgh Steelers vs. Buffalo Bills NFL playoff game hosted in bone-chilling Buffalo, New York.

The game was scheduled to be held Monday after being cancelled Sunday.

New York Gov. Kathy Hochul, a Buffalo native, posted a video on X, formerly known as Twitter, showing near-whiteout conditions.

"Conditions right now in Orchard Park, where the game would have started moments ago," she wrote early Sunday afternoon. "No visibility and dangerously high winds."

The Bills invited diehard fans to help dig out snow-filled Highmark Stadium, offering $20 an hour for their labour.

"We made progress shoveling, but not much at all," said Logan Eschrich, a storm chaser who made his way to Buffalo and pitched in.

It remains to be seen if the show will go on Monday afternoon. The weather service expects heavy lake-effect snow to push into upstate New York from Lake Erie, adding to the 1 to 2 feet (30.4 to 60.9 centimetres) of snow already blanketing the region. Snow fell at a rate of 2 inches per hour.

Sub-zero wind chills will grip much of the country, plunging to 50 degrees below zero in Montana and the Dakotas.

"It takes a matter of minutes for frostbite to set in," the South Dakota Department of Public Safety said in a statement Sunday urging people to stay indoors.

Other parts of the country could see temperatures drop 25 to 40 degrees below normal, from the Rockies to the Ohio Valley. As temperatures in Texas plunged, the state's power grid operator appealed to residents to voluntarily conserve electricity Monday morning due to the cold weather causing "record breaking demand" for energy.

A deadly freeze in 2021 left millions of Texans without power but state officials this week expressed confidence about the grid's reliability as the cold front approached. Freezing rain is expected to pelt parts of the Southern Plains and Southern Appalachians.

Even places like Florida won't be spared from turbulent weather, with forecasts predicting showers and thunderstorms from Monday into Tuesday.

In Oregon, more than 120,000 homes and businesses were without electricity, most of them in the Portland metro area, a day after high winds and a mix of snow and ice brought down trees and power lines.

Some 100 trees toppled over the weekend in a community just south of Portland, including one that fell on a house and killed a man.

Two other people died of suspected hypothermia and a fourth died in a fire that spread from an open-flame stove after a tree fell onto an RV.



PHOTO: RSS

Bull fighting in Taruka, Nuwakot on Monday on the occasion of Maghe Sankranti.

Reconstruction of three schools halted in Kavrepalanchok

BY KEDAR TIMALSINA
Banepa, Jan. 15

The reconstruction of school buildings in the Mahabharat Rural Municipality of Kavrepalanchok has come to a standstill because of negligence on the part of the contractor company.

The construction work of three schools in the district, initiated under the Disaster Resilience of Schools Project-3 (DRSP-3) with the assistance of the Asian Development Bank (ADB), is currently at a standstill.

The reconstruction works of Gokule Higher Secondary School in Ward No. 1, Kalidevi Higher Secondary School in Ward No. 2 and Janakalyan Higher Secondary School in Ward No. 8 at Ghartichhap, all in Mahabharat Rural Municipality, were initiated under the DRSP-3 initiative.

The agreement was signed between the Central Level Project Implementation Unit (CLPIU) and TDI-Ashish Construction Services Private Limited on October 22, 2021 to reconstruct three schools in the rural municipality.

Even though a contract was made to complete the construction of school buildings within one and a half years of the agreement, two years have already elapsed since the agreement was inked. The construction progress on any of the schools has not exceeded 60 per cent.

Engineer Ashok Adhikari from the CLPIU confirmed delays in the reconstruction work of the three schools in the district under the DRSP-3 initiative.

After the contractor company failed to complete the work within the agreed period, the contractor company was given a deadline of the end of March, said Adhikari.

"We have instructed the construction contractor company to complete the work by the end of March, and they have committed to finishing 90 per cent of the work within the extended date. If the work is not completed by the due date, legal action will be taken against the company," said Adhikari.

He mentioned that the ADB has also expressed concerns regarding the progress of the school building construction work. The contractor has completed 60 per cent work at Gokule Higher Secondary School, 55 per cent at Janakalyan Higher Secondary School, and 38 per cent at Kalidevi Higher Secondary School so far.

The headmaster of Gokule Higher Secondary School, Padam Prasad Timalsina, informed that the school building construction work had been in limbo for the past two years. He highlighted the absence of necessary amenities in the school, including a playground.

As the construction of the school buildings is not finished yet, there is a necessity to accommodate students of different classrooms on a single roof, owing to the lack of sufficient classrooms.

The contracts were awarded at Rs. 57.6 million, 57.7 million and 90.8 million for Gokule Higher Secondary School, Janakalyan Higher Secondary School and Kalidevi Higher Secondary School respectively.

However, the contractor company has received a payment of Rs. 24.6 million for the work at Gokule Higher Secondary School, Rs. 24.9 million for the Janakalyan, and Rs. 17.2 million for the Kalidevi Higher Secondary School, according to the Central Coordination Implementation Unit.

'Govt positive to declare Lakhan Thapa a martyr'

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 15

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has stressed the need to play a constructive role in safeguarding the rights enshrined in the Constitution while addressing two separate programmes organised in Kathmandu on the occasion of Maghi Festival on Monday.

At a programme organised by the Tharu community at Kathmandu's Tundikhel, the Prime Minister said that the governing Constitution was a document of consensus and political balance. He also asked all Nepalis to remain alert to protect the nation's achievements.

Meanwhile, at another Maghi Fair organised also at Tundikhel by the Magar community, Prime Minister Prachanda said that the government was positive about declaring Nepal's first martyr Lakhan Thapa a national hero. He said that he would take the needed initiative to make this happen.

He said, "I fully agree with your demand to declare the revolutionary Lakhan Thapa a national hero. This will not only honour all the martyrs who sacrificed their lives to fight against authoritarianism and bring about democracy in Nepal but also show respect to the revolutionary movements and political warriors of the country."

Rs. 700 million released for Rukum West

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Rukum West, Jan. 15

A total of Rs. 708,950,000 has been released from the District Disaster Fund for the construction of temporary shelters for earthquake-affected people in Rukum West.

According to the District Administration Office, the amount was distributed to the Local Disaster Fund of six local levels of the district.

Chief District Officer Hari Prasad Pant said that the amount was sent as the first instalment to 28,043 beneficiaries.

The local levels have already deposited Rs. 551,625,000 in the accounts of 22,665 beneficiaries, he added.

Rs. 156,975,000 was sent to Chaurahajari Municipality for 6,279 beneficiaries and the amount had been deposited in the accounts of 6,165 beneficiaries at the rate of Rs. 25,000 each, said Pant.

Similarly, in Aathbiskot Municipality, Rs. 243,300,000 was disbursed to 9,732 beneficiaries with a total of 7,728 beneficiaries receiving their first instalment.

In Musikot Municipality, 635 of 1,660 beneficiaries have received the amount. A total of Rs. 41,500,000 was released here. In Sanibheri Rural Municipality, Rs. 148, 025,000 was sent for 5,921 beneficiaries, and the first instalment has been deposited in the accounts of 4,485 beneficiaries.

In Tribeni Rural Municipality 2,752 beneficiaries have received the first instalment.

Meanwhile, Rs. 42,475, 000 was released for 1,099 beneficiaries in Banphikot Rural Municipality. But, none have received the amount yet as the process has not started due to the transfer of the Chief District Officer.

NOC slashes fuel prices

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 15

The Nepal Oil Corporation (NOC) has reduced the fuel prices from midnight today. Issuing a press statement today, the NOC said that the price of petrol, diesel and kerosene has decreased by Rs 1 per litre.

According to the NOC, the price of petrol is fixed Rs 163.5 per litre in Charali, Biratnagar, Janakpur, Amlekhgunj, Bhalbari, Nepalgunj, Dhangadhi and Birgunj and Rs 153.5 per litre to diesel and kerosene in those depots.

Likewise, the price of per litre petrol is fixed Rs 165 in Dang and Surkhet, and Rs 166 in Kathmandu, Pokhara and Dipayal.

The NOC shared that the price of petroleum products was slashed as per the new price list received from the Indian Oil Corporation.

Kathmandu...

However, the tunnel was closed again in April 2022 for a month due to increased fears of floods. Former Minister for Water Supply Chaudhary once again inaugurated the water supply from the distribution centre at Mahankal in Kathmandu on December 9, 2022.

With the fifth inauguration of the Melamchi Drinking Water Project, the denizens of Kathmandu and Lalitpur will be receiving water supply from the much-talked-about project.

According to spokesperson for Kathmandu Upatyaka Khanepani Limited (KUKL) Prakash Rai, they have been supplying water at 6 million litres per hour since Monday afternoon.

Rai said that they are supplying water to Mahankal Chowk, Anamnagar, Minbhawan, Khumaltar, Kirtipur, Balaju, Panipokhari and Bansbari by Monday evening. However, the people in Bhaktapur and Thimi will be supplied with water only from Tuesday.

"We will supply water regularly to the people until we do not face any disturbance in the supply system," Rai said.

NA election code comes...

Spreading false, misleading, or malicious information on social media, engaging in hate speech, and insulting other candidates to influence the election is also prohibited.

Maintaining the confidentiality of voters, refraining from disputes with voters or election staff at polling stations, and avoiding actions that compromise the impartiality and fairness of the election are mandatory during the period.

It said the ministers of the federal and provincial governments, along with public office bearers involved in the election campaign, would not be allowed to use government resources without permission from the commission.

A year on, kin of air tragedy...

Meanwhile, our Lekhnath correspondent Phadindra Adhikari reports that the Pokhara Metropolitan City has erected a memorial at the site of last year's plane crash.

The names and addresses of all those who were aboard the tragic flight have been carved on the memorial, unveiled by Mayor Dhana Raj Acharya on Monday.

Acharya also informed that the metro had allocated Rs. 1 million to build a memorial park at the Seti Gorge between wards 7 and 15 of the city. "We have asked the chairs of both the wards to take responsibility for it and have also talked with Yeti Airlines about it," he said on the occasion.

The metropolis plans to develop the park as a destination for tourists, Pokhara denizens and relatives of the deceased.

The accident site still has parts of the crashed plane scattered around it.

The Aircraft Accident Investigation Commission formed in the aftermath of the crash concluded last month that the plane crashed because of the inadvertent movement of both condition levers to the feathered position.

'Let's build quake resistant structures...

In addition, classes on earthquake safety as well as conduct artificial event practice (simulation) will be conducted at every school on that day in partnership with the concerned local government.

There have been projections of the possibility of a powerful earthquake in the western region of Nepal as this region has not received a major jolt in the last four or five centuries.

Speaking at a programme in Lalitpur a couple of weeks ago, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' said that the earthquakes in Jajarkot, Bajhang and Doti within a year had foreshadowed this.

Even a year ago, six people died and hundreds of houses were damaged in Doti-Bajura earthquake.

PM Prachanda said that there was indifference to the pre-disaster risk assessment and the corresponding structures and preparations. "Therefore, the series of earthquakes this time has forced us to have risk-resistant structures and continuous preparations accordingly.

Now my emphasis is on making rapid preparations for reconstruction, preparing earthquake resistant designs, making strong structures and arranging sufficient budget," he had said, "This work should not be delayed."

The government has also maintained that it will not create another reconstruction body to carry out the post-quake rebuilding in Jajarkot and Rukum West but amend the laws to further empower the NDRRMA by equipping it with resources and by strengthening its organisational structure of this authority.

PM Prachanda had already instructed the Authority to make an action plan for adequate preparations for search and rescue equipment, tents for relief and other materials to be made available in all provincial godowns, district godowns and local levels.

Similarly, the Cabinet has already decided that the Chief Secretary of the government will study and submit a report regarding the insurance of all buildings and structures including personal residences and government offices.

UK PM to face lawmakers over decision to strike on Yemen's Houthis

AP
London, Jan. 15

Prime Minister Rishi Sunak was due to face Parliament Monday to explain why the U.K. joined the U.S. in striking Houthi targets in Yemen — and why British lawmakers did not get a say on the military action.

Four Royal Air Force Typhoon jets took part in last week's U.S.-led strikes on sites used by the Iran-backed rebels, who have been attacking commercial ships in the Red Sea. The U.S. says Friday's strikes hit Houthi weapons depots, radar facilities and command centers.

The Houthis say they have targeted ships linked to Israel in response to the war in Gaza. But they have frequently attacked vessels with no clear links to Israel, imperiling shipping in a key route for global trade.

U.S. forces carried out another strike Saturday on a Houthi radar site.

British Defense Secretary Grant Shapps said Monday that Friday's strikes had been intended "as a single action" rather than part of a campaign, but did not rule out U.K. participation in further military strikes.

"We will now monitor very carefully to see what (the Houthis) do next, how they respond and we will see from there," he said. Keir Starmer, leader of Britain's main opposition Labour Party, said he supported last week's strikes but expects more openness from the government in future.

"If the government is proposing further action, then it should say so and set out the case, and we're going to have to consider that on a case-by-case basis on the merits," he said.



PHOTO: AP

Britain's Prime Minister Rishi Sunak gestures during his visit to The Boatyard in Leigh-on-Sea, Essex, England, Monday.

The smaller opposition Liberal Democrats accused the government of "riding roughshod over a democratic convention" that Parliament should get a vote on military action.

"For Rishi Sunak to attempt to ignore elected representatives is disgraceful," Liberal Democrat defense spokesman Richard Foord said.

Sunak's government is facing mounting demands on Britain's ever-shrinking military in an increasingly volatile world. Hours after the strikes on the Houthis, Sunak was in Kyiv, where he announced a further 2.5 billion pounds ($3.2 billion) in military aid to Ukraine and signed a long-term security agreement with President Volodymyr Zelenskyy.

Sunak — whose Conservative Party trails Labour in opinion polls ahead of an election due this year — also is struggling to revive his stalled plan to send asylum-seekers to Rwanda.

The Rwanda plan is an expensive, highly controversial policy that hasn't sent a single person to the East African country so far. But it has become a totemic issue for Sunak, central to his pledge to "stop the boats" bringing unauthorized migrants to the U.K. across the English Channel from France. More than 29,000 people made the perilous journey in 2023. Five people died on the weekend while trying to launch a boat from northern France in the dark and winter cold.

London and Kigali made a deal almost two years ago under which migrants who reach Britain across the Channel would be sent to Rwanda, where they would stay permanently.

Have you visited the real Pimbahal?

BY AASHISH MISHRA
Lalitpur, Jan. 15

Kristin Bajracharya finds solace near the Jaga Madu Pond in Lalitpur Metropolitan City-20 every day after work. "The area is always buzzing with life and exudes a cheerful ambience," said the 29-year-old.

"This place – Pimbahal – can make you forget all your cares," she added with a smile.

Likewise, 33-year-old Bigyan Khanal comes here every other week to indulge in what he claims are the unparalleled delights of Pimbahal crisps. "Ain't no crisps like Pimbahal crisps," he proclaimed.

However, the name Pimbahal brings a question to mind: where is the Bahal, the Buddhist monastic courtyard, of this Bahal? The Rising Nepal put this question to a dozen people, both locals and visitors, on Sunday, and received varied responses. Some thought the Gavarmapintha Mahavihar to the west of the Jaga Madu Pond (which itself is referred to as Pimbahal Pond) was Pimbahal while others guessed that it could be the locality around the prominent white Ashok Stupa. Some also admitted they did not know.

But a person who did know was local Triratna Shakya. Shakya, 85, is the Thakali Aju (Eldest among the elders) of Mubahal and is a member of the communal trust that conducts ritual worship (Puja) at the Ashok Stupa.



Photo Courtesy: Adish Deep Shakya

Despite holding the name, this is not the real Pimbahal, the yard pictured below is.



Talking to The Rising Nepal, he clarified that the Gavarmapintha Mahavihar was not Pimbahal, but actually the Mubahal he leads, and informed the area around the Jaga Madu Pond earned the name Pimbahal simply because it was in proximity to the erstwhile Pimbahal.

Hold on a second! Erstwhile? Does this mean that the Bahal no longer exists? "Not in the form you'd expect," Shakya replied, walking into a confined quadrangle less than 50 metres north of the white Stupa.

The quad, surrounded by houses on three sides, is a tiny – and surprisingly quiet – space invisible from the main street (if you can call it that). It is paved with tiles and has a quaint well at the centre.

"This used to be Pimbahal," Shakya, a retired Chief Survey Officer of the Survey Department, revealed. To laypeople, nothing in the precinct would betray its history as a wing of a Buddhist monastery. But Shakya is no layperson. He is the 'eldest of the elders' after all.

"And look at this," despite his age he was able to run to what looked like the ruins of a building. "Look at this!" he stressed.

"This could be where [Pimbahal's] main deity was housed," he hypothesised. "I remember once seeing his throne here," he said, pointing to the top of the grass-and-weed-covered mound.

"This is where Pimbahal was," Shakya reiterated.

Where the gods went silent

Quoting Varnavajra Vajracarya's book 'Cwabaha Karunamaya Bakha' (Tales of Chobar Karunamaya), researcher John Kerr Locke SJ, in his 1980 publication 'Karunamaya,' associates Pimbahal with Manjushree, the figure who, according to Buddhist legends, made Kathmandu Valley inhabitable by draining the lake that covered it.

Locke writes that, aeons after first making Kathmandu liveable, Manjushree returned to pray at the Sri Tin Jyotirupa Swayambhu accompanied by the Kashyap Tathagat.

During their visit, the two felt they needed to stay in the Valley to teach and guide the people here. So, they set up a Vihar (monastery) at Pimbahal and appointed an Acharya and his family as their dyo palas (priestly attendants).

However, after several generations, disputes arose among the Acharya's descendants about who had the right to serve the two divinities. Based on Vajracarya's work, Locke writes that this dispute was solved when the heirs decided to take turns.

But, by this time, the world had entered the most sinful of the eras, the Kali Yuga, and the two deities decided that they could not continue to stay at Pimbahal and pay direct attention to their devotees. So, they decided to disappear into their images. Locke describes, "While they would continue to grant favours to the people, they decided they would no longer speak with them."

The Dyo Palas, their relatives and the ordinary worshippers, though, were not aware of this decision. Everyone thought the Palas failed to keep the gods happy and killed them all, except for one old man.

This violence made the old man, who was spared out of respect for his advanced age, angry. "What is the use of worshipping you?" he rebuked the gods. "Because of you, my whole family has been murdered."

In his rage, the man removed the images of Manjushree and Kashyap and threw them into a river at the Arya Tirtha and the Shanti Tirtha respectively. One Hem Acharya later recovered Kashyap's image and consecrated it at Patan's 'Golden Temple.'

As for the Manjushree figure, the river carried it to a place called Jaya Tirtha where a man named Suval Acharya found it. Through his Sadhana, this man removed the life force from the figure and transferred it to another statue that he then placed at the top of the Kakshapal Hill at Chobar. This statue later got the name Anandadi Lokeshwor.

Thus, if the legend is to be believed, Pimbahal is a sacred land where divine beings once lived.

So, next time you visit Pimbahal, enjoy the vibrant atmosphere, immerse yourself in the lively surroundings and seek out the divine sanctuary that once thrived here. When at Pimbahal, do not



Puppet play 'Chiruchiru Michiru' staged

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 15

The puppet play 'Chiruchiru Michiru' was staged at Theater Mall Kirtipur.

The play, written, conceived, and directed by Erina Saji, a Japanese theatre artist with a background in Puppet Theater, showcased the culmination of a 10-day puppet theatre workshop.

The puppet play was jointly organised by Uttaravision Theatre Japan, Theatre Centre For Children Nepal, and Theatre Mall.

The workshop, facilitated by Rarahil Memorial School and ASSITEJ International, marked its conclusion with the production of 'Chiruchiru Michiru,' which Utervision plans to stage in Japan in March.

In this child-friendly play, the narrative unfolds the dream journey of two children in search of a bluebird.

Throughout their adventure in the supernatural world, they encounter various characters.

The drama artfully portrayed their efforts and the exciting events they faced through a combination of actors and puppets.

Notably, in 'Chiruchiru Michiru,' the two children, upon awakening from their dream, contribute to curing a neighbour's sick daughter by gifting them a bluebird.

A diverse cast, including Shankar Bhandari, Sabeer Churaute, Susmita Guragain, Pooja Dhakal, Manju Giri, Rajya Laxmi Maharjan, Manju Maharjan, Abha Pradhan, Saujan Limbu, Shobha Karki, Suman Napit and Saubhagya Singh actively participated in both the drama and puppet workshop.

The workshop, led by four artists, including director Erina Saji from Japan, was a collaborative effort to promote Puppet Theatre in Nepal.

Emmys finally arrive for a changed Hollywood, as 'Succession'

AP
Los Angeles, Jan 15

The time has finally come for a most unusual Emmys.

The 75th Primetime Emmy Awards are arriving four months past their due date on Monday night at the Peacock Theater, coming after a year of historic Hollywood turbulence in an industry whose upheavals are evident everywhere.

Strikes by both actors and writers, seismic shifts toward streaming, and the dismantling of the traditional TV calendar mean the envelopes opened during the Fox telecast hosted by Anthony Anderson on Martin Luther King Jr. Day will display winners that were decided months ago for shows that in some cases were completed years ago — and have a fraction of the audience they had a few decades ago.

But for actors and others taking part in the ceremony, norms just aren't a thing anymore in this business.

"Since the pandemic it's been really strange, you shoot something, then sometimes it's another couple years until you see it, and a while longer until something like this," actor Nick Offerman told The Associated Press last week after winning an early Emmy for " The Last of Us," a show that is among Monday night's top nominees along with "Succession," "Ted Lasso" and "The Bear."

The Emmys will provide some respite and celebration after the strike and the troubles that spurred it, and with its 75th edition, will attempt to provide links to its past and to TV history.

It will include a series of cast reunions and scene recreations from beloved shows including "Cheers," "Game of Thrones," "Grey's Anatomy" and "Martin."

The nominations themselves provide one big link to Emmys past — the continuation of the decades-long dominance of HBO, which this year has the three most nominated shows with "Succession," "The White Lotus" and "The Last of Us."

Anderson has been tasked with hosting at a time when emceeing awards shows is hardly a coveted job, especially after comic Jo Koy was widely roasted for his Golden Globes performance last weekend.

But Anderson said he's actually coming in relaxed and relieved, because for the first time in nearly a decade, he's not a nominee. He never won an Emmy despite 11 nominations as a producer and actor for his former show, "black-ish."

"All the pressure is off of me now," Anderson, now the host of Fox's "We Are Family," said during ceremony preparations.

"I don't have to sit there and wonder, am I going to win? Am I going to get it? What time are they going to get to this category? I just get to come up here and be myself."



HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: The fire within might be hard to keep down. You may feel strong frustration throughout the day, since your ruler, Mars, is facing off with the Moon and bringing out your inner flames.

Taurus: You might feel like a pressure cooker. The customer isn't always right, but sometimes you still must smile and nod even as a client, boss, or peer majorly stresses you out. Unfortunately.

Gemini: A group that you're in might be pushing your buttons. It can be difficult to be who you are in a gathering of others who agree with each other -- but not with you. You may feel like you're being ganged up on at times.

Cancer: Your responsibilities to others could be tricky at present. Keeping your word is probably very important to you, so you could easily end up with difficult or stressful responsibilities or be drawn into a spiral of nit-picking or shifting requirements.

Leo: Impulsivity can speedily land you in hot water! This is specifically connected to throwing away things that you still need, going traveling without scheduling time off from your responsibilities, or moving on from a connection that you're not ready.

Virgo: Increased sensitivity could negatively impact your day. You'll potentially You might react more strongly to jokesters trying to get a laugh, or you may see others as attacking you when they're really not.

Libra: You might feel caught in the middle. This may be a back and forth between two people that are close to you. Even if you can see the problem between them, you may not be able to make them understand.

Scorpio: What you're feeling can spur you to say things that you don't mean. Just because you're feeling stressed from a busy routine, low energy levels, or those who would disrespect you, doesn't mean that you should then take these feel.

Sagittarius: The darkest places can be lit by your inner fire. This blaze of passion may not be stable, since you could have to give up some creature comforts or solid situations to pursue your less tangible goals.

Capricorn: Tradition might seem to be working against you. While you may appreciate regulations in some areas of life, they're possibly beginning to feel outdated in others. You're ready to move forward in a way that old rules would forbid.

Aquarius: You could feel lost today. Seemingly dependable pals might vanish in your hour of need, leaving you wondering where you're supposed to turn to. Exhaustion is valid, as having to navigate certain.

Pisces: Alienating others might sound like a good idea -- but that's your insecurities talking! You probably believe that you're protecting yourself, but the people who genuinely care about you could feel completely.

CARTOON

gocomics.com



Egypt struggles at AFCON, Japan favourites to lift Asian Cup

AP
Abidjan, Ivory Coast Jan. 15



PHOTO: AP

Mozambique's Alfons Amade, right goes to tackle Egypt's Mohamed Salah during the African Cup of Nations Group B soccer match between Egypt and Mozambique in Abidjan, Ivory Coast, Sunday, Jan. 14, 2024. The match ended in a 2-2 draw.

Big names Mohamed Salah and Victor Osimhen endured a difficult start to the Africa Cup of Nations as Sunday turned into a day for the underdog.

Salah needed to score a late penalty to spare Egypt's embarrassment by drawing 2-2 against Mozambique, and Osimhen was unable to lift Nigeria to a winning start as the "Super Eagles" were held 1-1 by Equatorial Guinea in their opening game.

Four-time champion Ghana conceded in injury time to lose 2-1 to Cape Verde, maintaining the small Atlantic island nation's record of never losing its opening Africa Cup game in four tournament appearances.

"It's a big team in Africa, in the world. Ghana has a lot of good players. But we showed tonight that we have a good team, good players, and we deserved to win," Cape Verde veteran Ryan Mendes said.

Salah stayed cool to score from the spot in the seventh minute of second-half stoppage time after Domingos was adjudged to have fouled Mostafa Mohamed in a VAR review.

That denied Mozambique its first-ever tournament win at the 13th attempt. But the team was still cheered by the majority of fans at the Félix Houphouët-Boigny Stadium.

Salah had also set up Mohamed to fire in the opener in the second minute of the Group B game.

The stadium, which had been filling up with Ghana and Cape Verde fans for the later match at the same venue, erupted when Mozambique winger Witi equalized with a header to Domingos' cross in the 55th, and again three minutes later when Clésio Baúque fired the underdogs in front.

"It's not the names that play, it's the team, it's everybody," said Mozambique defender Reinildo. "We all save, we all play, we all score, we all concede. That's what does it."

Fans booed when the seven minutes of injury time was announced and cries of "Mozambique, Mozambique" rang around the stadium.

But Salah showed no nerves as he salvaged a point for "The Pharaohs" as they began their bid for a record-extending eighth title.

Osimhen scored but missed several good chances as Equatorial Guinea held on to draw 1-1.

Goalkeeper Jesús Owono produced a string of saves to frustrate three-time champion Nigeria in the second half after Osimhen had equalized in the first.

Nigeria dominated from the start only to be caught out in the 36th minute when José Machín set up Iban Salvador to fire Equatorial Guinea ahead.

Osimhen replied around a minute later when Ademola Lookman's deflected cross dropped kindly for him to head in at the far post.

The result leaves coach José Peseiro's team under pressure going into Thursday's game against host nation Ivory Coast, which started the tournament Saturday with a 2-0 win over Guinea-Bissau.

Cape Verde substitute Garry Rodrigues scored in stoppage time for a 2-1 win over four-time champion Ghana in Group B.

The "Blue Sharks" got off to a great start with Jamiro Monteiro scoring in the 17th minute on a rebound from Jovane Cabral's initial shot saved by Richard Ofori in the Ghana goal.

Marshaled at the back by Roberto "Pico" Lopes and Logan Costa, Cape Verde's defense largely dealt with Ghana's speedy forward line of Jordan Ayew, Antoine Semenyo and Joseph Paintsil.

Majeed Ashimeru thought he'd equalized in the 36th with a long-range strike inside the left post after Ransford-Yeboah Königsdörffer's header had ricocheted off the post for Ghana. But a VAR check deemed the retreating Königsdörffer was in an offside position and blocking the goalkeeper's view.

The "Black Stars" finally equalized when Alexander Djiku headed in Ayew's corner in the 56th.

Paintsil went close shortly afterward as coach Chris Hughton's halftime talk evidently had the desired effect on his players. He sent on Iñaki Williams, Ernest Nuamah and veteran André Ayew, who equaled a record by playing in eight Africa Cups.

Cape Verde's substitute had the final say, however.

Likewise, Big wins for Japan and Iran on Sunday backed up their pre-tournament billing as two of the favorites to lift the Asian Cup.

Record four-time champion Japan came from behind to beat Vietnam 4-2 in Group D, and Iran overcame the Palestinian soccer team 4-1 in Group C.

Japan is the standout favorite to triumph in Qatar after its dominance was broken over the last two editions of the tournament.

It has not lifted the trophy since 2011 — ending a run that saw it win four out of six titles. And it suffered an early shock when trailing 2-1 to a Vietnam team ranked 94th by FIFA, before powering back to avoid an upset.

Army club, APF clinch victory in PM's cup

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 15

In a compelling match of the Prime Minister's Cup One Day National Cricket Tournament, Tribhuwan Army Club secured a resounding victory, triumphing over Madhesh by 126 runs in Kirtipur.

Opting to bat after losing the toss, the Tribhuwan Army amassed a formidable total of 320 runs in their allotted 50 overs. Captain Binod Bhandari played a stellar innings, scoring 113 runs off 93 balls, adorned with 9 fours and 6 sixes. Openers Imran Sheikh and Santosh Karki contributed with 26 and 42 runs respectively, while Kushal Malla and Vivek Yadav chipped in with 37 runs each. Ranjit Kumar claimed the most wickets for Madhesh, securing 5 dismissals, supported by Bishal Patel with 2 wickets, and Rupesh Singh and Rajesh Yadav with 1 wicket each.

In pursuit of the challenging target of 321 runs set by the Army, Madhesh was bowled out for 194 runs in 48.3 overs. Pawan Saraf top-scored with an impressive 65 runs, featuring 7 fours and 3 sixes in 3 balls. Opener Mayan Yadav contributed 34 runs, while Rajesh Yadav remained unbeaten on 32 runs. Sahab Alam led the bowling attack for the Army, taking the most 4 wickets, supported by Sompal Kami with 2 wickets, and Jitendra Mukhia and Kushal Malla with 1 wicket each.

This defeat marks the first setback for Madhesh, who had earlier secured a win against Koshi by 7 wickets, while Tribhuvan Army continues their winning streak after clinching the first match.

Similarly, in a commendable display of all-round excellence by Captain Rohit Kumar Paudel, the APF Club clinched their second consecutive victory in the Prime Minister's Cup One Day National Cricket Tournament, triumphing over Koshi by 6 wickets.

In pursuit of a 136-run target for victory at Mulpani Cricket Ground, APF reached the mark in 19.1 overs with 4 wickets down. Captain Rohit Paudel showcased his cricketing prowess by not only taking 3 wickets but also delivering an outstanding batting performance, amassing a half-century with 80 runs off 53 balls, inclusive of 9 fours and 3 sixes. Opener Prajwal Shahi contributed with 22 runs, and Sumit Maharjan remained unbeaten on 20 runs.

Batting after losing the toss, Koshi managed to post a total of 135 runs in 44.3 overs. Firod Ansari led the scoring with a half-century of 55 runs.

However, APF's bowling attack, spearheaded by Rohit Paudel and Abhinash Bohora with 3 wickets each, restricted Koshi's batting lineup. Amar Rautela secured 2 wickets, while Bhuvan Karki and Shyam Dhakal each claimed 1 wicket.

The collaborative brilliance of Captain Rohit Paudel's all-round performance played a pivotal role in APF's commanding victory, securing their second win in the tournament.

CHITWAN VICTORIOUS IN BAGMATI PROVINCIAL VOLLEYBALL CUP

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Jiri, Jan. 15

In a thrilling competition held in Jiri of Dolakha district, Chitwan emerged victorious in the Bagmati Provincial Level volleyball cup, securing the Hemanta Pradhan Memorial Cup. The tournament, organized by the Nepali Congress Dolakha Provincial Constituency (A) in memory of the late Nepal Tarun Dal leader Hemanta Pradhan, concluded on Sunday.

Chitwan claimed the top spot and received a prize of 2 lakhs in cash, along with a shield, medal, and certificate. Ramechhap secured the second position, earning a cash prize of one lakh, along with similar accolades. Sindhuli, securing third place, was awarded 50 thousand in cash and a certificate, while Dolakha received 30 thousand in cash and a certificate for solace.

In recognition of their outstanding performances, individual players were also honoured. Nabin Mahato from Chitwan was named the best player, Roshan Magar from Ramechhap received the best Spiker title, Saroj Haya from Sindhuli was recognized as the best server, Manjil Gurung from Chitwan was awarded the best scorer, Manish Rai from Chitwan earned the title of best blocker, and Mikel Ale from Ramechhap was honoured as the best defender.

The Nepali Congress Dolakha Provincial Constituency (A) committee chair, Sukra Raj Tamang, presented the medals, trophies, and cash prizes at a function held in Jiri. Twelve teams from various districts of Bagmati Province participated in the competition, showcasing the spirit of sportsmanship and camaraderie.

SRI LANKA BEATS ZIMBABWE BY 3 WICKETS

AP
Colombo, Sri Lanka Jan. 15

No. 11 batter Dushmantha Chameera scored the winning runs off the last ball of the match as Sri Lanka beat Zimbabwe by three wickets in their Twenty20 opener on Sunday.

Angelo Mathews top-scored for Sri Lanka with 46 and shared 55 runs for the seventh wicket with Dasun Shanaka, who was at the other end on 26 not out when Chameera came out to face the last two balls.

The dramatic finish came after Sri Lanka captain Wanindu Hasaranga won the toss and chose to field at R. Premadasa Stadium.

Zimbabwe made 143-5 in 20 overs. In reply, Sri Lanka slumped to 83-6 as Zimbabwe captain Sikandar Raza's brilliant three wickets threatened to take the game away from the hosts.

Real Madrid beats Barcelona 4-1 to win Spanish Super Cup

AP
Riyadh, Saudi Arabia Jan. 15



Vinícius Júnior did his best Cristiano Ronaldo impression in Saudi Arabia, scoring a hat trick and leading Real Madrid to a 4-1 rout of Barcelona and the Spanish Super Cup trophy.

Vinícius scored his three goals in the first half as Madrid beat Barcelona to lift its first trophy of the season on Sunday. After his first goal, the Brazil forward imitated the trademark celebration of the former Madrid great, with Ronaldo reportedly at the Riyadh stadium.

"It was for Cris, because he is my idol and now he is playing here," said Vinícius, who was named the best player of the final. "I'm very happy with myself and with my team. It's not easy to play against Barcelona and to win 4-1 is tough. We played an almost perfect match."

Rodrygo also scored for Madrid, which now has 13 Super Cup trophies, one less than the Catalan club. It was Madrid's second Super Cup triumph since the tournament was moved to Saudi Arabia four years ago. Robert Lewandowski scored Barcelona's goal to make it 2-1 in the first half.

The "clasico" between the Spanish powerhouses was a rematch of last year's Super Cup final that Barcelona won 3-1 for its first trophy with coach Xavi Hernández and without Lionel Messi.

Madrid had also won at Barcelona in the first "clasico" of the season in October in the Spanish league.

Barcelona played a man down from the 71st after defender Ronald Araujo was shown a second yellow card for a foul on Vinícius. Madrid was already winning 4-1 at the time. The victory added to Madrid's momentum as Carlo Ancelotti's team remains unbeaten in 21 consecutive games in all competitions. Its last setback was a 3-1 loss at Atletico Madrid in the Spanish league in September.

In contrast, the defeat adds to Barcelona's troubles and increases the pressure on Xavi, whose team hasn't played well recently. It trails second-place Madrid by seven points in the Spanish league, with Catalan opponent Girona another point ahead at the top having played an extra game.

"We are disappointed and sad," Xavi said. "We were hopeful of another victory, but in the end it was our worst match. We didn't get off to a good start and were never comfortable. We have to congratulate Madrid because it deserved to win."

It didn't take long for Madrid to take control of the match in Riyadh, with Vinícius scoring his first goals since a long injury absence in the seventh, 10th and 39th minutes. It was Vinícius' third match since being out from November because of an injury picked up with Brazil's national team in a World Cup qualifier.

"Vinícius is back," Ancelotti said. "He needed these two or three games to get back to his best form."

Vinícius opened the scoring after an assist by Jude Bellingham, dribbling past Barcelona goalkeeper Iñaki Peña before finding the open net. The second goal came in a breakaway after an assist by Rodrygo, and the third was a penalty kick he converted after being pulled down by Araujo.

Lewandowski had moved Barcelona within a goal with a shot from inside the area in the 33rd, but Madrid remained in control during the rest of the match to secure a comfortable victory.

Rodrygo's goal came in the 64th after a pass by Vinícius was deflected by Barcelona defender Jules Koundé inside the area. Madrid made it to the final by defeating Atletico Madrid 5-3 in extra time in the first semifinal on Wednesday, while Barcelona got past Osasuna 2-0 on Thursday.

Madrid qualified for the Super Cup after beating Osasuna in the Copa del Rey final last season, while Barcelona made it to the tournament as the Spanish league champion.

Madrid also won the trophy when the Super Cup's revamped "Final Four" format debuted in Saudi Arabia in 2020 in the first of a lucrative multi-year deal for the clubs and the Spanish soccer federation. The move to Saudi Arabia was heavily criticized by women's and human rights groups for allegedly helping an authoritarian regime clean up its image.

Madrid midfielder Toni Kroos, who has criticized the decision by top players to play in Saudi Arabia, was booed again by the Saudi crowd on Sunday.

Man Utd vs Tottenham

Tottenham twice came from behind to draw 2-2 at Manchester United in the Premier League on Sunday as British billionaire Jim Ratcliffe attended his first match since agreeing a deal for a partial takeover at Old Trafford.

Ratcliffe's agreement to buy a 25% stake and take control of soccer operations has brought some hope to a club that has fallen off the top of the English game under its owners, the Glazer family.

But it is a long way back and fans will continue to protest the Americans' involvement, no matter how diminished, with Ratcliffe getting a first-hand look at the challenge he is taking on in the draw with Spurs.

The 71-year-old Ratcliffe, who grew up supporting United, sat next to former manager Alex Ferguson in the directors' box at Old Trafford and only had to wait three minutes to celebrate as summer signing Rasmus Hojlund hammered home a shot into the roof of the net.

Richarlison headed in a 19th-minute equalizer from a corner for his sixth goal in as many Premier League matches, but Marcus Rashford put the hosts back ahead in the 40th after a one-two with Hojlund.

Cristian Romero rattled the United crossbar in stoppage time and, 49 seconds into the second half, Rodrigo Bentancur slammed Spurs level after capitalizing on some sloppy home defending.

WEATHER

Tuesday

Sunrise at 6:56 am, Sunset at 5:30 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Tuesday)

Partly to generally cloudy in the hilly regions and mainly fair in the rest of the country. Brief rain and chances of light snowfall are likely to occur at one or two places in hilly regions and mountainous regions of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province respectively.

Expected Temp.: 18-20 Rain Probability: 0%

Monday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	17.0	4.5	0.0
Dipayal	23.8	5.3	0.0
Dhangadi	15.8	7.2	0.0
Birendranagar	23.0	5.2	0.0
Nepalgunj	14.8	11.2	0.0
Jumla	18.5	-5.2	0.0
Ghorahi	23.0	7.5	0.0
Pokhara	22.0	8.4	0.0
Bhairahawa	14.0	8.2	0.0
Simara	13.9	10.4	0.0
Kathmandu	19.5	5.2	0.0
Okhaldhunga	19.0	9.2	0.0
Taplejung	18.2	5.6	0.0
Dhankuta	24.0	8.5	0.0
Biratnagar	18.7	7.6	0.0
Jomsom	13.0	0.5	0.0*
Dharan	23.0	10.0	0.0*
Lumle	17.1	6.5	0.0*
Janakpur	18.8	9.4	0.0*
Jiri	16.6	0.7	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 16, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.32	Rs. 132.92
Euro	1	Rs. 144.84	Rs. 145.49
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.43	Rs. 169.19
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 155.01	Rs. 155.72
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 88.18	Rs. 88.58
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.61	Rs. 99.06
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.25	Rs.99.70
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.09	Rs. 9.13
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.44	Rs. 18.52
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.28	Rs. 35.44
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.29	Rs. 36.46
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.79	Rs. 3.80
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.03	Rs. 36.19
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.34	Rs. 28.47
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.01	Rs. 10.06
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.85	Rs. 12.91
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.42	Rs. 19.51
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.92	Rs. 17.00
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.55	Rs. 432.50
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.00	Rs. 352.59

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Published by Executive Chairman **Bishnu Prasad Subedi** and General Manager **Lal Bahadur Airi** for the Gorkhapatra Corporation • Printed at G.S. Press, Kathmandu • Acting Editor-in-Chief: **Bhimsen Thapaliya**
Phone: Editorial 5322279 • Advertisement 5327493, 5331394 • Distribution 5320638 • E-mail: mgorkhapatra@gmail.com, trnfeatures@hotmail.com • Registered No. 29/028/022 • G.P.O. 30/053/54